

UPSC Mock Examination — International Relations, South Asia & Current Affairs

Date: 14 June 2026 | Maximum Marks: 165 | Time: 3 Hours

Topics: GS-2: 21st Century World Order | India & South Asia | Pakistan & Afghanistan | CA Week June 7–13 2026

INSTRUCTIONS:

- This paper has 4 Sections: Section A (MCQ + CSAT), Section B (10-mark Mains), Section C (20-mark Mains), Section D (Essay).
- Section A: Each MCQ carries +2.00 for correct answer, -0.66 for wrong answer, 0 for unattempted.
- Section B: Answer any 3 questions in approximately 150 words each. Each question carries 10 marks.
- Section C: Answer both questions in approximately 250 words each. Each question carries 20 marks.
- Section D: Attempt ONE essay from the two choices. Essay carries 25 marks (1000–1200 words).
- Answers must be written in the separate Answer Booklet provided. Do NOT write answers on this paper.
- Use of maps, diagrams and flowcharts is encouraged in Mains answers where appropriate.
- Mobile phones and electronic devices are strictly prohibited inside the examination hall.

SECTION A — OBJECTIVE (MCQ + CSAT) (70 Marks | +2.00 Correct | -0.66 Wrong | 0 Unattempted)

Read each question carefully. Choose the single best answer from options (A), (B), (C), (D).

■ Part A-1 — Conceptual (Q1–10) | 2 marks each

Questions based on static concepts from GS-2 syllabus: World Order, India's Foreign Policy, UNSC, India-Pakistan, Indus Waters, SAARC.

Q1. Which of the following best describes the concept of 'unipolarity' in international relations?

- | | |
|--|--|
| (A) A system in which one state holds preponderant power across military, economic and diplomatic domains, unchallenged by any rival | (B) A balance-of-power system maintained through competing alliances between roughly equal major powers |
| (C) A world order governed primarily by multilateral institutions such as the UN and WTO, with no single dominant state | (D) A multipolar configuration in which three or more roughly equal great powers compete simultaneously for global influence |

Q2. Which of the following best describes India's shift from 'Non-Alignment' to 'Multi-Alignment' in its foreign policy?

(A) India has formally joined military alliances with the USA and France, effectively replacing its founding Non-Aligned Movement membership

(B) India pursues issue-based partnerships with multiple competing powers simultaneously while retaining strategic autonomy and avoiding binding alliance commitments

(C) India has abandoned its founding principle of peaceful coexistence in favour of realpolitik driven purely by great-power competition dynamics

(D) Multi-alignment exclusively prioritises economic partnerships over security interests in all of India's bilateral relationships

Q3. Consider the following statements regarding UN Security Council (UNSC) reform:

1. The G4 group — India, Brazil, Germany and Japan — advocates for expansion of the UNSC's permanent membership.

2. The 'Uniting for Consensus' (UfC) group, led by Italy and including Pakistan and South Korea, opposes any expansion of permanent membership.

3. Any UNSC reform requires amendment of the UN Charter, ratified by two-thirds of all UN General Assembly members including all five current permanent members.

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

(A) 1 only

(B) 1 and 2 only

(C) 1, 2 and 3

(D) 2 and 3 only

Q4. Which of the following is the correct chronological order of major India-Pakistan armed conflicts?

(A) Indo-Pakistani War of 1965 → First Kashmir War (1947) → Bangladesh Liberation War (1971) → Kargil Conflict (1999)

(B) First Kashmir War (1947) → Bangladesh Liberation War (1971) → Indo-Pakistani War of 1965 → Kargil Conflict (1999)

(C) First Kashmir War (1947) → Kargil Conflict (1999) → Indo-Pakistani War of 1965 → Bangladesh Liberation War (1971)

(D) First Kashmir War (1947) → Indo-Pakistani War of 1965 → Bangladesh Liberation War (1971) → Kargil Conflict (1999)

Q5. With reference to the Instrument of Accession signed by Maharaja Hari Singh in October 1947, which of the following is correct?

(A) It was signed on 26 October 1947, acceding Jammu & Kashmir to India specifically on three subjects: Defence, External Affairs and Communications

(B) The Instrument was conditional, explicitly requiring a plebiscite to be conducted within 90 days under UN supervision

(C) The Indian Independence Act 1947 legally compelled all Princely States to accede to either India or Pakistan without any alternative

(D) Pakistan filed a protest with the UN General Assembly, arguing that the Instrument of Accession was legally invalid under the Partition plan

Q6. Consider the following statements about the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT), 1960:

1. India has exclusive use rights over the three eastern rivers — Ravi, Beas and Sutlej.
2. Pakistan has exclusive use rights over the three western rivers — Indus, Jhelum and Chenab.
3. The World Bank mediated the IWT negotiations and is listed as a party (facilitator) to the Treaty.
4. The Treaty contains no internal dispute resolution mechanism — all disputes must be referred directly to the International Court of Justice.

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 2 only

(B) 1, 2 and 3 only

(C) 3 and 4 only

(D) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Q7. Which of the following is NOT a primary reason for SAARC's inability to function as an effective regional integration body comparable to ASEAN?

(A) The consensus-based decision-making structure that allows any single member state to veto or block collective regional initiatives

(B) Persistent India-Pakistan bilateral tensions that consistently paralyse collective decision-making and summit scheduling

(C) The complete absence of any permanent secretariat or administrative structure to coordinate SAARC's regional programmes

(D) The lack of a dedicated intra-SAARC commercial or investment dispute resolution mechanism

Q8. Consider the following statements about the Shimla Agreement (1972):

1. It converted the ceasefire line in Jammu & Kashmir into the Line of Control (LoC).
2. It committed both India and Pakistan to resolving all disputes bilaterally, without third-party intervention or mediation.
3. It was signed by Prime Minister Indira Gandhi and President Zulfikar Ali Bhutto.
4. It recognised Pakistan's sovereign claim over the entire Kashmir Valley, pending a future UN-supervised plebiscite.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 4 only

(B) 2 and 4 only

(C) 1, 2 and 4 only

(D) 1, 2 and 3 only

Q9. The 'stability-instability paradox' as applied to South Asia's nuclear environment means:

(A) Nuclear deterrence prevents full-scale conventional war between India and Pakistan, but simultaneously provides strategic cover for sub-conventional proxy warfare and cross-border terrorism

(B) Nuclear weapons create macro-level strategic stability while domestic political instability in the nuclear state undermines reliable deterrence calculations

(C) The quantitative asymmetry between India's and Pakistan's nuclear arsenals creates systemic instability in bilateral deterrence signalling

(D) Pakistan's declared first-use nuclear doctrine fundamentally destabilises South Asian deterrence by undercutting India's No-First-Use commitment

Q10. Which of the following correctly describes why India officially objects to the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC)?

(A) CPEC passes through Aksai Chin, which China administers but India claims as part of Ladakh — making it a violation of India's territorial integrity

(B) CPEC passes through Gilgit-Baltistan, which India considers an integral part of Jammu & Kashmir, making the project an infringement on Indian sovereignty claims over the region

(C) CPEC is funded entirely through Chinese grants, establishing a permanent Chinese military and economic footprint with no debt obligations on Pakistan

(D) CPEC connects China's Yunnan province to Pakistan's Karachi port, creating a land route that geographically encircles India from the west

■ **Part A-2 — Advanced / Application (Q11–20) | 2 marks each**

Questions require analysis and application of concepts across GS-2 sub-topics: Two-front challenge, Indo-Pacific, multilateral groupings, nuclear doctrine, supply-chain security.

Q11. India's 'two-front' security challenge in strategic discourse primarily refers to:

(A) The simultaneous requirement to deter both nuclear and sub-conventional attacks from Pakistan across different escalation ladders

(B) The need to manage land border insurgencies in the Northeast while simultaneously projecting maritime power in the Indian Ocean

(C) The strategic threat posed by the de facto China-Pakistan axis, which may require India to simultaneously defend its northern (China) and western (Pakistan) fronts in a crisis

(D) The challenge of balancing domestic counter-insurgency operations in Kashmir while maintaining conventional deterrence against Pakistani armoured formations

Q12. Consider the following pairs of foreign policy doctrines and descriptions:

1. Neighbourhood First Policy — India prioritises immediate neighbours via connectivity, development finance and people-to-people ties.

2. BIMSTEC — A 7-member sub-regional grouping linking South and Southeast Asia through the Bay of Bengal, that excludes Pakistan.

3. Gujral Doctrine — India should apply non-reciprocity towards smaller neighbours, giving more than it takes, to build strategic goodwill.

4. Act East Policy — Launched in 2014, it expands India's outreach beyond ASEAN to East Asia, Pacific nations and deeper security engagement.

Which of the above pairs are CORRECTLY matched?

(A) 1 and 2 only

(B) 1, 2 and 3 only

(C) 2, 3 and 4 only

(D) 1, 2, 3 and 4 — all are correctly matched

Q13. With reference to India's engagement with Afghanistan after the Taliban takeover in August 2021, which of the following is/are correct?

1. India completely severed all diplomatic ties with Kabul immediately after the Taliban takeover in 2021 and has maintained no official presence in Afghanistan since then.
2. Afghanistan holds strategic value for India as a potential gateway to Central Asia via the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC).
3. Pakistan perceives the Taliban's return to power as strategically advantageous, as it reduces India's diplomatic and development footprint in Afghanistan.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 2 and 3 only

(B) 1 and 2 only

(C) 1, 2 and 3

(D) 3 only

Q14. Which of the following statements accurately describes India's declared nuclear doctrine?

(A) India maintains a 'first use' nuclear option to compensate for an assumed conventional military imbalance on its western front vis-à-vis Pakistan

(B) India's declared doctrine is 'No First Use' (NFU) of nuclear weapons, combined with a commitment to credible minimum deterrence and massive punitive retaliation if India suffers a nuclear attack

(C) India's Nuclear Command Authority is chaired by the Defence Minister, who holds sole authority over nuclear deployment decisions

(D) India has developed tactical battlefield nuclear weapons for theatre-level deterrence specifically against Pakistan's armoured corps

Q15. Which of the following developments placed supply-chain security at the centre of major powers' national security frameworks?

1. The COVID-19 pandemic exposed dangerous over-dependence on single-source, geographically concentrated supply chains, especially for pharmaceuticals, PPE and electronics.
2. The global semiconductor shortage of 2020–22 disrupted automotive, defence and consumer electronics industries, revealing critical chokepoint vulnerabilities.
3. China's control of 60–85% of global rare earth element processing capacity creates a structural single-point-of-failure in defence, clean energy and advanced technology supply chains.

Which of the above contributed to making supply-chain security a strategic priority for major powers?

(A) 1 only

(B) 1 and 2 only

(C) 1, 2 and 3

(D) 2 and 3 only

Q16. With reference to the Indo-Pacific as a strategic construct, which of the following is correct?

(A) The Indo-Pacific concept was formally initiated by India through the 'Act East Policy' in 2014 and was subsequently adopted by the United States

(B) The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QUAD) is a formal mutual-defence alliance under the Indo-Pacific framework, with treaty obligations comparable to NATO's Article 5

(C) China actively participates in QUAD exercises and broadly endorses the Indo-Pacific framework as a platform for inclusive trade and infrastructure cooperation

(D) The Indo-Pacific framework treats the Indian Ocean and Pacific Ocean as an integrated strategic domain, reflecting converging trade, security and geopolitical interests across both oceanic regions

Q17. Consider the following about multilateral groupings involving South and Southeast Asian nations:

1. BIMSTEC has 7 members — Bangladesh, India, Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Thailand, Nepal and Bhutan — and excludes Pakistan.
2. The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) admitted India and Pakistan as full members in 2017 and Iran in 2023.
3. Afghanistan became SAARC's 8th and most recent full member in 2007.
4. The Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA) includes littoral states from South Asia, East Africa, West Asia, Southeast Asia and Australia.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 1, 2, 3 and 4

(B) 1 and 3 only

(C) 2 and 4 only

(D) 1 and 4 only

Q18. The Lahore Declaration (February 1999), signed by Prime Ministers Vajpayee and Nawaz Sharif, primarily committed India and Pakistan to:

(A) A comprehensive bilateral ceasefire along the entire Line of Control in Jammu & Kashmir, to be monitored by UN military observers

(B) Nuclear risk reduction measures, intensifying the composite dialogue process, and resolving all outstanding bilateral issues exclusively through peaceful means

(C) Pakistan's formal acceptance of the Line of Control as the de facto permanent international boundary in Jammu & Kashmir

(D) A bilateral moratorium on nuclear testing pending entry-into-force of the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty (CTBT), with joint IAEA verification

Q19. India's policy of 'strategic patience' towards Pakistan, particularly evident after the Balakot airstrikes (February 2019), refers to:

(A) India's unconditional readiness to resume composite dialogue with Pakistan regardless of ongoing cross-border terrorist activity

(B) India's preference for UN or US mediation as the primary mechanism to resolve the Kashmir dispute bilaterally

(C) India's posture of firm deterrence, calibrated signalling and avoidance of hasty escalation — waiting for internal contradictions within Pakistan's civil-military establishment to create conditions for meaningful dialogue

(D) India's permanent acceptance of the status quo on the Line of Control and a deliberate policy of avoiding any kinetic military options across the LoC

Q20. India's advocacy for 'Reformed Multilateralism' in global governance debates refers to:

(A) India's demand to dissolve all existing international institutions and create entirely new bodies that reflect the current distribution of global power from scratch

(B) India's support for complete elimination of the P5 veto power in the UNSC in order to fully democratise global governance decision-making

(C) India's preference for bilateral and minilateral formats (such as QUAD, G20 and SCO) over traditional multilateral institutions in resolving global disputes

(D) India's call to reform existing multilateral institutions — particularly expanding UNSC permanent membership and giving emerging economies greater voting weight in the IMF and World Bank — to reflect current global power realities

■ **Part A-3 — Current Affairs: Week June 7–13, 2026 (Q21–30) | 2 marks each**

Questions based on major events and developments from the week of 7–13 June 2026. Verify all options against current affairs sources.

Q21. With reference to the strategic significance of the Strait of Hormuz, which of the following is correct?

- | | |
|---|--|
| (A) The Strait of Hormuz connects the Persian Gulf to the Red Sea and separates Iran's coastline from Saudi Arabia's eastern shores | (B) Approximately 20–22% of global oil consumption and around 20% of global LNG supplies pass through the Strait of Hormuz, making it the world's most critical oil transit chokepoint |
| (C) Under UNCLOS, the Strait of Hormuz lies entirely within Iran's exclusive territorial waters, giving Iran the legal right to impose transit conditions | (D) Kharg Island — Iran's primary crude oil export terminal — is located at the southern entrance of the Strait of Hormuz itself |

Q22. With reference to US military strikes on oil tankers crewed by Indian sailors (June 8–11, 2026), which of the following is correct?

- | | |
|--|---|
| (A) India formally invoked Article 87 of UNCLOS to protest violation of freedom of navigation against Indian-flagged vessels operating on the high seas | (B) All three targeted vessels were registered under the Indian flag, making them Indian sovereign vessels and directly engaging India's state responsibility under international law |
| (C) The vessels MT Settebello, MT Marivex and MT Jalveer were flagged under third countries — Palau and Guinea-Bissau — illustrating the global 'flag of convenience' ship registration system | (D) India recalled its Ambassador from Washington DC in protest over the killing of Indian sailors by United States military forces |

Q23. The theme of the 11th Governing Council meeting of NITI Aayog, chaired by PM Narendra Modi on June 11, 2026, was:

- | | |
|--|---|
| (A) 'Digital Economy and Innovation for Viksit Bharat 2047' | (B) 'Cooperative Federalism: Building a Developed India Together' |
| (C) 'Amrit Kaal: From Vision to Action for Sustainable Growth' | (D) 'Inclusive Human Development for Viksit Bharat @2047' |

Q24. A tripartite MoU signed between Assam, Nagaland and the Central Government in June 2026 pertains to:

- | | |
|--|--|
| (A) Resuming oil and mineral exploration in the Disputed Area Belt (DAB) along the Assam-Nagaland border — operations suspended for over 30 years — with revenues shared equally (50:50) between both states | (B) Establishing a new Joint Delimitation Commission under the Ministry of Home Affairs to permanently resolve the Assam-Nagaland boundary dispute |
| (C) Creating a Northeast Special Economic Zone along the Assam-Nagaland border to attract manufacturing investment and promote ASEAN-facing exports | (D) Formalising a structured ceasefire protocol between Assam state police forces and the NSCN (I-M) armed cadres operating in the border zone |

Q25. With reference to India's four Labour Codes, whose Central Rules were notified in 2025–26, which of the following is/are correct?

1. Gig workers and platform workers are classified as 'employees' under the Code on Social Security and are fully entitled to EPF and ESI contributions from platform companies.
2. Fixed-Term Employment workers are entitled to gratuity on a pro-rata basis after completing one year of service, without waiting for the standard five-year threshold.
3. No State government can fix a minimum wage below the national floor wage notified by the Central Government under the Code on Wages.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 3 only

(B) 2 and 3 only

(C) 1, 2 and 3

(D) 1 only

Q26. Consider the following statements about the Nipah virus and India's preparedness response:

1. The Nipah virus was first identified in India during the 2018 Kerala outbreak, making Kerala the site of its global discovery.
2. In India, the National Institute of Virology (NIV), Pune serves as the designated reference laboratory for confirming Nipah virus samples.
3. The WHO has classified Nipah as a Blueprint Priority Disease for which no approved human vaccine or specific antiviral drug currently exists.

Which of the above is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 2 only

(B) 1 and 3 only

(C) 2 and 3 only

(D) 1, 2 and 3

Q27. Which of the following correctly represents India's current demographic reality and the constitutional challenge associated with delimitation?

(A) India's national Total Fertility Rate (TFR) remains above 3.0, requiring continued population control legislation in all states including those in the south

(B) The 84th Constitutional Amendment permanently froze delimitation of parliamentary constituencies until a separate constitutional amendment explicitly lifts the freeze

(C) The forthcoming delimitation will automatically reduce southern states' Lok Sabha seat share because seats are determined solely by population, without any demographic correction mechanism

(D) India's national TFR has declined to approximately 1.9 — below the replacement rate of 2.1 — while southern states like Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh record TFRs as low as 1.3–1.6

Q28. The Supreme Court's landmark June 2026 ruling creating the 'Loss of Domestic Care' compensation head for homemakers in motor accident claims:

(A) Fixed ₹30,000 per month as the minimum notional income for calculating MACT compensation for homemakers, with mandatory upward revision of 10% every three years

(B) Directed the Central Government to establish a national statutory minimum wage of ₹30,000 per month for all domestic workers and full-time homemakers across India

(C) Ordered that the economic value of unpaid domestic work be formally included in India's GDP calculation under the revised System of National Accounts

(D) Mandated all insurance companies to automatically value homemaker policyholders' contribution at ₹30,000 per month for life and health insurance premium and payout calculations

Q29. The proposed 114-aircraft Rafale deal between India and France (2026) differs from the earlier 36-aircraft Rafale agreement (2016) primarily because:

(A) The 2026 deal is exclusively for Rafale-Marine naval jets for INS Vikrant, while the 2016 deal was entirely for Rafale-F3R for the Indian Air Force

(C) The 2026 deal is structured as a direct commercial contract between Dassault Aviation and HAL, while the 2016 deal was a government-to-government arrangement

(B) Unlike the 2016 fly-away purchase which involved no Transfer of Technology, the 2026 deal envisages full Transfer of Technology with up to 90 jets manufactured in India under the Make in India programme

(D) The 2026 deal includes nuclear-capable Rafale variants, directly linked to India-France civil nuclear cooperation under the Jaitapur Nuclear Power Plant agreement

Q30. The India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), which entered into force on June 1, 2026, holds strategic importance for India primarily because:

(A) It grants Indian workers unlimited work permits and long-term residency rights in Oman, directly protecting the ~780,000-strong Indian diaspora's employment security in the GCC

(C) Oman hosts the strategically vital Duqm and Salalah deepwater ports, giving India alternative maritime access routes that reduce dangerous dependence on the Strait of Hormuz for Gulf energy and trade transit

(B) Being India's first CEPA with a GCC member, it creates automatic preferential market access for India across all six Gulf Cooperation Council member states

(D) The CEPA's classified defence annex grants the Indian Navy permanent basing rights at Oman's Duqm port on the Arabian Sea, expanding India's blue-water naval presence

■ Part A-4 — CSAT: Reading Comprehension, Data Interpretation & Analytical Reasoning (Q31–35) | 2 marks each

Questions test reading comprehension, data interpretation and logical reasoning. No specific domain knowledge is required.

Q31. Read the following passage and answer the question below. "Strategic autonomy in Indian foreign policy has evolved from Non-Alignment's ideological neutrality during the Cold War to a pragmatic multi-alignment that seeks beneficial partnerships across competing blocs without formal binding commitments. This approach allows India to extract maximal advantage from each bilateral relationship — defence technology from the USA, nuclear cooperation from France, energy and fertilisers from Russia, and market access through China — while preserving freedom of action in future crises. It is not a doctrine of equidistance but of equi-engagement." Which of the following inferences is most directly and accurately supported by the passage?

(A) India's multi-alignment strategy is ideologically identical to its Non-Alignment posture during the Cold War era

(C) India has formed binding military alliances with the USA, France and Russia as part of its multi-alignment foreign policy

(B) India maintains exact equidistance from all major powers as the philosophical foundation of its multi-alignment strategy

(D) Multi-alignment enables India to simultaneously benefit from partnerships with competing major powers without binding commitments that would constrain its future strategic choices

Q32. A foreign policy analyst makes the following observations about Country X: P: Country X signs a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) with another country ONLY IF it already has formal diplomatic relations with that country. Q: Country X has just announced a signed FTA with Country Y. R: Country X had no formal diplomatic relations with Country Z as recently as last year. Which of the following conclusions is DEFINITELY AND NECESSARILY TRUE based solely on statements P, Q and R?

- (A) Country X has formal diplomatic relations with Country Y
 (B) Country X has recently established diplomatic relations with Country Z
 (C) Country X will sign an FTA with Country Z in the near future
 (D) Country X cannot sign any trade agreement with a country in which it has no resident trade offices

Q33. The table below shows India's defence exports over five years. Based solely on this data, which of the following conclusions is CORRECT?

Year	Defence Exports (■ crore)
2019-20	9,116
2020-21	8,435
2021-22	13,000
2022-23	15,920
2023-24	23,622

- (A) Defence exports declined in 2020-21 due to COVID-19 and remained below 2019-20 levels throughout the entire observation period
 (B) India's defence exports grew by approximately 159% between 2019-20 and 2023-24, more than doubling over the five-year period
 (C) The single highest year-on-year percentage growth rate was recorded between 2022-23 and 2023-24
 (D) India had already achieved its stated defence export target of ■50,000 crore per year by 2023-24

Q34. India allocates its bilateral development assistance budget of ■10,000 crore as follows: South Asia — 35%, Africa — 25%, Central Asia — 20%, Southeast Asia — 20%. If India increases its South Asia allocation by exactly 10% of the current South Asia figure (while keeping the total budget constant at ■10,000 crore), what percentage of the total budget will South Asia now receive?

- (A) 37.5%
 (B) 38.0%
 (C) 38.5%
 (D) 40.0%

Q35. Read the following passage and answer the question below. "The Durand Line, drawn in 1893 between British India and Afghanistan by Sir Henry Mortimer Durand, has never been formally recognised by any Afghan government as a legitimate international boundary. This 2,670-km line divided Pashtun tribal communities and has remained a persistent source of tension between Pakistan — as the successor state to British India's territorial claims — and successive Afghan governments. Notably, even the Taliban, despite being widely perceived as strategically aligned with Pakistan, has continued to contest the legitimacy of the Durand Line as an international border." Which of the following is an inference that CANNOT be drawn from the passage alone?

(A) The Durand Line has never had consensus legitimacy from the Afghan side since its original demarcation in 1893

(B) The Pashtun ethnic community was geographically divided across two separate administrative territories by the Durand Line

(C) Even actors widely considered to be Pakistan's strategic allies, such as the Taliban, dispute the legitimacy of the Durand Line as an international border

(D) India formally supports the redrawing of the Durand Line in order to reunite divided Pashtun communities across the Afghan-Pakistan border

SECTION B — MAINS SHORT ANSWER (30 Marks | Attempt any 3 questions | 10 Marks each | 150 words each)

Attempt any THREE questions from this section. Each answer must be within 150 words. Use the directive word as your analytical anchor. Provide a structured response with an introduction, analysis, examples and a conclusion.

Q3 6. Examine India's transition from 'Non-Alignment' during the Cold War to 'Multi-Alignment' in the 21st century. How does this evolution reflect both continuity and change in India's pursuit of strategic autonomy?

GS-2 | International Relations | 10 Marks | Answer in 150 words

Q3 7. Critically analyse the structural and political factors that have prevented SAARC from realising its potential as an effective regional integration body comparable to ASEAN. In light of these limitations, assess the relevance of sub-regional mechanisms (BIMSTEC, BBIN) as strategic alternatives.

GS-2 | India and its Neighbourhood | 10 Marks | Answer in 150 words

Q3 8. Discuss the 'stability-instability paradox' in the context of India-Pakistan nuclear deterrence. How does mutual nuclear deterrence simultaneously prevent large-scale conventional war yet provide strategic cover for sub-conventional proxy conflict and cross-border terrorism?

GS-2/GS-3 | India-Pakistan Relations | Nuclear Deterrence | 10 Marks | Answer in 150 words

Q3 9. Analyse the strategic significance of the Lahore Declaration (1999) and the Shimla Agreement (1972) in the context of India-Pakistan bilateral relations. Why have formal bilateral agreements failed to create a durable architecture for peace in South Asia?

GS-2 | India-Pakistan Relations | 10 Marks | Answer in 150 words

SECTION C — MAINS LONG ANSWER (40 Marks | Both questions compulsory | 20 Marks each | 250 words each)

Both questions in this section are compulsory. Each answer must be within 250 words. Higher marks are awarded for multi-dimensional analysis, use of current examples and a well-structured argument that addresses multiple GS papers where applicable.

- Q4 0.** The rise of China as a global power presents the most consequential strategic challenge for India in the 21st century. **Analyse** the key dimensions of India-China strategic competition — territorial, economic, diplomatic and maritime — and examine how India is managing this complex relationship through strategic balancing, multilateral hedging and border infrastructure development.

GS-2 | India-China Relations | Indo-Pacific | 20 Marks | Answer in 250 words

- Q4 1.** 'Water has emerged as the new frontier of strategic competition in South Asia.' **Critically examine** the strategic dimensions of the Indus Waters Treaty in the evolving India-Pakistan relationship, the legal and geopolitical implications of India's recent decision to put the Treaty in abeyance, and India's broader policy options in water diplomacy as an instrument of foreign policy.

GS-2/GS-3 | Water Diplomacy | India-Pakistan Relations | 20 Marks | Answer in 250 words

SECTION D — ESSAY (25 Marks | Attempt ONE essay from the two choices | 1000–1200 words)

Attempt ONE essay from the two choices below. Your essay will be evaluated on: Depth of analysis, Coherence of argument, Use of relevant examples (contemporary + historical), Philosophical or ethical dimension (if applicable), and Quality of written expression. A well-structured essay with a clear thesis, developed body paragraphs and a reflective conclusion is expected. Length: 1000–1200 words.

- Q4 2.** **Essay Choice 1:** 'Strategic autonomy is not isolationism but principled engagement — India's multi-alignment strategy in a world of competing great powers.'

GS-2 Essay | International Relations | 25 Marks | 1000-1200 words

- Q4 3.** **Essay Choice 2:** 'The neighbourhood is not merely geography but destiny — rethinking India's approach to South Asia in an era of Chinese strategic expansion.'

GS-2 Essay | India and South Asia | 25 Marks | 1000-1200 words

— END OF QUESTION PAPER —

Total: 165 Marks | UPSC Practice Paper | Copilot CLI UPSC Agent